PRINCIPLE IV: AI-ASSISTED LANGUAGE EDUCATION SHOULD BE HUMAN-CENTRED

Guideline 8

Empower language teachers as reflective professionals

About this guideline

Language teachers working in AI-assisted classrooms must simultaneously manage the immediate demands of instruction and maintain a reflective distance from their practice. Artificial intelligence, used thoughtfully, can support both of these demands by helping teachers plan more deliberately, observe more systematically, and interpret their teaching more deeply. Guideline 8 draws on established frameworks for reflective practice (Farrell, 2022; Schön, 1983) to propose ways in which AI can support teachers as inquirers into their own language teaching.

Just like any other instance of teaching, AI-assisted language education also requires that teachers engage in regular **reflection** about their professional practice. This involves being able to effectively plan forward (reflection-for-action), which can be supported, for example, by generating variants of a lesson or activity with different degrees of autonomy (e.g., tightly scaffolded vs. open-ended), or counterfactual scenarios (e.g., "what would happen if I only had one student?") and making structured comparisons between them. It also involves the ability to make pedagogical judgments in (almost) real time, by deploying keen observation skills and pedagogical sensitivity for monitoring the implementation of AI-assisted activities. Finally, conversational agents can be leveraged to provide input and feedback after lessons or longer instructional sequences, prompting reflection on the less "accessible aspects of teachers' work" (D. Freeman, 2016, p. 208), and thus making professional action more purposeful.

Artificial intelligence can also be used to support forms of **professional development**, such as classroom-based inquiry, whether framed as action research (Burns, 2010), exploratory practice (Hanks, 2017), or teacher-led scholarship (Sato & Loewen, 2022). For example, teachers can assign large language models the role of a critical friend whose task it is to help define and collaboratively refine a teaching-related puzzle. Alternatively, they could reformulate broad areas of investigation into more precise and researchable research questions. Assuming ethical and legal safeguards are met (see Section 2.3), artificial intelligence can also be used to transcribe audio or video recordings of classroom interactions, identify recurring patterns such as specific grammatical deviations or discourse markers, or compare student outputs or proficiency across lessons or groups, thus facilitating systematic analysis.

With appropriate prompting, AI can promote **teacher reflexivity** (Edge, 2011) by helping teachers theoretically position themselves and their teaching practices. Choices about how AI is used inevitably position language education within a broader landscape of values. For example, a teacher who routinely uses AI to generate multiple-choice grammar items may be communicating to learners that

language learning is mostly about accuracy and measurable outcomes. By contrast, a teacher who uses the same tools to scaffold creative writing might be making different statements about what language education is for. Using AI tools to interrogate and make explicit the pedagogical assumptions embedded in a lesson plan or activity, or to propose an alternative version grounded in a different set of values, can make these choices visible and deliberate rather than habitual. Over time, such reflective habits shape how learners, school leaders, policymakers, and the public come to understand language teaching as an intellectually serious and socially committed professional practice.

For example…

Here's a prompt that can be used to reflect on a lesson

"You will assume the role of a critical friend and experienced language educator. Your task is to help me reflect on a lesson I taught today to upper-intermediate learners on expressing opinions in English. The main activity was a debate, and I integrated an AI chatbot for brainstorming arguments. I want to evaluate the effectiveness of this lesson in supporting learner autonomy and engagement. Ask me probing questions about the structure of the lesson, the role of AI, and learner responses. Please focus on: (a) what worked well and why, (b) what I need to do differently in the future, and (c) how AI influenced the dynamics of the lesson. Present your questions in a way that encourages me to reflect critically and constructively, so I can improve the next iteration of this lesson."

References

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Edge J. (2011), *The reflexive teacher educator in TESOL: roots and wings*, Routledge, London.

Farrell T. S. C. (2022), *Reflective practice in language teaching*, Cambridge University Press, Cambridge.

Freeman D. (2016), *Educating second language teachers*, Oxford University Press, Oxford.

Hanks J. (2017), *Exploratory practice in language teaching: puzzling about principles and practices*, Palgrave Macmillan, London, available at: https://doi.org/10.1057/978-1-137-52998-7.

Sato M. and Loewen S. (2022), "The research–practice dialogue in second language learning and teaching: past, present, and future", *The Modern Language Journal*, Vol. 106, Issue 3, pp. 509-527, available at: https://doi.org/10.1111/modl.12791.

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Competences and reflection questions

8.1 I can use AI to strengthen my reflective practice

Descriptor: *How rigorously do I use AI to reflect on my teaching practices?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- How often do I use AI tools to revisit a lesson or activity?
- When I ask an AI tool to comment on my teaching, do I provide enough contextual detail for its feedback to be genuinely useful?

- How well do the patterns an AI tool identifies in my practice align with my own professional interpretations?
- How might I systematically record AI-assisted reflections over time to track the development of my thinking?

8.2 I can critically reflect on my use of AI

Descriptor: *How critically do I use AI to systematically explore aspects of my teaching practice?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- How do I identify which aspects of my teaching are worth investigating?
- Which aspects of classroom-based inquiry can be handled well by artificial intelligence and which require more human engagement?
- Do I use AI tools to surface assumptions in my lesson plans or materials that I might not have noticed myself, or do I mainly use them to confirm decisions I have already made?

8.3 I can align my use of AI with my teaching values

Descriptor: *How deeply can I reflect on the values implicit in my use of artificial intelligence?*

REFLECTION QUESTIONS

- Thinking about the AI-supported activities I use most frequently, what do they collectively suggest about my teaching beliefs?
- How would I explain the values embedded in my AI use to a learner, a parent, or a policymaker?